Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) or ‘Dravidian Progress Federation’. Much the same goes for the SOAS statue. But what both statues also celebrate are Thiruvalluvar’s humble origins, which is why he is such a hero to the common man, and why his bearded image can be seen on the dashboards of buses and lorries all over South India.

So who exactly was Thiruvalluvar?

His name is made up of two Tamil words. *Thiru* is the local equivalent of the Sanskrit honorific *sri*, and with the same added implication of ‘holy’. However, *Valluvar* refers to a tribe of astrologers, astronomers and medicine men who were said to have acted as priests to the Pandya rulers in Madurai long before the arrival in South India of the first Brahmin priests, after which the Valluvar were relegated to the lowest rung on the Hindu social ladder. Most accounts describe Thiruvalluvar as born of a Brahmin father by an outcaste Paraiyar mother. So Thiruvalluvar is very much a symbol of the emergence of the oppressed underclasses after centuries of oppression by the higher castes.

No one knows for certain when Thiruvalluvar lived, or where he lived, and some question if he ever lived, and perhaps it doesn’t matter. Popular tradition has it that he was a weaver by occupation who lived with his dutiful wife in Mylapore (now swallowed up by Chennai), where his supposed house is now a temple with its own statue akin to that on the SOAS lawn. However, in 2005 this widely accepted version was challenged by the Kanyakumari Historical and Cultural Research Centre, which announced that it had established Thiruvalluvar’s true origins. A name inscribed on a tenth-century copper plate had led them to the most southerly section of the Western Ghats, known in British days as the Tinnevelly Range but carrying a variety of far older names, including Pothigai Malai, Pothiyam Malai, Agastya Malai and Mahendra Giri.

This is the same thickly forested mountain country that constitutes the homeland of the semi-nomadic hunter-